

048. Chapter 4 Verses 14-17

Lectures by Swami Sarvapriyananda

VERSE 4.14

न मां कर्माणि लिम्पन्ति न मे कर्मफले स्पृहा ।
इति मां योऽभिजानाति कर्मभिर्न स बध्यते ॥ 14 ॥

na mām karmāṇi limpanti na me karma-phale spṛihā
iti mām yo 'bhijānāti karmabhir na sa badhyate

na—not; mām—me; karmāṇi—activities; limpanti—taint; na—nor; me—my; karma-phale—the fruits of action; spṛihā—desire; iti—thus; mām—me; yaḥ—who; abhijānāti—knows; karmabhiḥ—result of action; na—never; saḥ—that person; badhyate—is bound

Actions do not taint Me, nor have I desire for the fruit of actions; He who knows Me thus is not bound by karma.

VERSE 4.15

एवं ज्ञात्वा कृतं कर्म पूर्वैरपि मुमुक्षुभिः ।
कुरु कर्मैव तस्मात्त्वं पूर्वैः पूर्वतरं कृतम् ॥ 15 ॥

evam jñātvā kṛitaṁ karma pūrvair api mumukṣhubhiḥ
kuru karmaiva tasmāttvaṁ pūrvaiḥ pūrvataraṁ kṛitaṁ

evam—thus; **jñātvā**—knowing; **kṛitaṁ**—performed; **karma**—actions; **pūrvaiḥ**—of ancient times; **api**—indeed; **mumukṣhubhiḥ**—seekers of liberation; **kuru**—should perform; **karma**—duty; **eva**—certainly; **tasmāt**—therefore; **tvam**—you; **pūrvaiḥ**—of those ancient sages; **pūrvataṁ**—in ancient times; **kṛitaṁ**—performed

Thus knowing, the ancient spiritual aspirants performed the action. Therefore you shall do the same (desireless) action as performed by the ancients in older times.

VERSE 4.16

किं कर्म किमकर्मेति कवयोऽप्यत्र मोहिताः ।
तत्ते कर्म प्रवक्ष्यामि यज्ज्ञात्वा मोक्ष्यसेऽशुभात् ॥ 16 ॥

kim karma kim akarmeti kavayo 'pyatra mohitāḥ
tat te karma pravakṣhyāmi yaj jñātvā mokṣhyase 'śhubhāt

kim—what; **karma**—action; **kim**—what; **akarma**—inaction; **iti**—thus; **kavayaḥ**—the wise; **api**—even; **atra**—in this; **mohitāḥ**—are confused; **tat**—that; **te**—to you; **karma**—action; **pravakṣhyāmi**—I shall explain; **yaj**—which; **jñātvā**—knowing; **mokṣhyase**—you may free yourself; **aśhubhāt**—from inauspiciousness

What is action, and what is not action? In this matter, even the wise are deluded. I will teach you that action knowing which you shall be liberated from evil.

VERSE 4.17

कर्मणो ह्यपि बोद्धव्यं बोद्धव्यं च विकर्मणः ।
अकर्मणश्च बोद्धव्यं गहना कर्मणो गतिः ॥ 17 ॥

karmaṇo hyapi boddhavyaṁ boddhavyaṁ cha vikarmaṇaḥ
akarmaṇaśh cha boddhavyaṁ gahanā karmaṇo gatiḥ

karmaṇaḥ—recommended action; **hi**—certainly; **api**—also; **boddhavyam**—should be known; **boddhavyam**—must understand; **cha**—and; **vikarmaṇaḥ**—forbidden action; **akarmaṇaḥ**—inaction; **cha**—and; **boddhavyam**—must understand; **gahanā**—profound; **karmaṇaḥ**—of action; **gatiḥ**—the true path

The nature of action (enjoined by the Sastras) and of wrong action (prohibited by the Sastras) and also of inaction should be known, because deep and difficult to understand is the path of action.